

Cash in hand

The shift to a cashless society is now well under way, but banknotes and coins are still widely used—especially for paying out small amounts such as when buying a newspaper or a cup of coffee. Many small businesses, especially in less developed parts of the world, also don't have the facilities to deal with payments other than in cash. So, although it's no longer necessary to have large sums of money when you go out, you'll probably need to have some cash in your pocket. And if, like most people, your money is in the bank, you'll need to withdraw spending money from time to time, either by visiting your bank, or from an ATM (automated teller machine) using your debit or credit card.



Holding all the cards

It's these cards, and the technology behind them, that have revolutionized the way we pay for things today. In addition to using cards to withdraw cash from an ATM, you can use them to pay for things directly, and to pay for things that you order on the phone, or online. Stores and businesses worldwide now accept debit and credit cards in payment, and some stores even issue their own credit cards—known as store cards—which can be used to buy things from them. Modern cards are made from plastic—paying by card is sometimes referred to as “using plastic”—with magnetic strips or electronic chips embedded in them, which can be read by a store's card machine. Once you have verified the transaction by entering your PIN (personal